

SEVEN DAYS IN SAIGON

Marcus's Uni-Break Adventure — Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

Bowls of Pho • Banh Mi on the Go • Museums • History • Backpacker Budget • Outsmarting the Traffic

DAY 1 · Sat

Boots Down in Bui Vien

AM — Land, drop your pack at a D1 hostel (Bui Vien / Pham Ngu Lao) — backpacker central.

PM — Wander Ben Thanh Market, crane your neck at Bitexco, stroll neon-lit Nguyen Hue.

EVE — First bowl of pho — the ritual that kicks off every trip right.

Food: Pho Hoa Pasteur — silky beef pho, ~70,000 VND.

■ *Traffic tip: Skip the taxi — D1 is walkable and traffic-free on foot.*

DAY 2 · Sun

Ghosts of Saigon

AM — War Remnants Museum, doors-open 7:30am — go before the tour buses do.

PM — Reunification Palace's time-capsule halls, then Notre-Dame & the grand Post Office.

EVE — Banh mi by Turtle Lake as the city exhales into evening.

Food: Banh Mi Huynh Hoa — the legendary loaded baguette, ~65,000 VND, cash only.

■ *Traffic tip: All 4 stops sit within 1.5km — one lazy loop, zero Grab rides.*

DAY 3 · Mon

Into the Tunnels

AM — Wheels up 7:00am for Cu Chi — outrun the rush before it even starts.

PM — Duck through the tunnels that outlasted an army; simple lunch on site.

EVE — Back by ~4pm, feet up, early night for the next adventure.

Food: Banh trang nuong — Vietnam's smoky 'pizza,' ~25,000 VND.

■ *Traffic tip: Grab the earliest slot — an 8am start means an hour stuck in traffic instead of tunnels.*

DAY 4 · Tue

Marble Halls & Old Saigon

AM — HCMC Museum's colonial grandeur, then incense curling through Jade Emperor Pagoda.

PM — Fine Arts Museum — cheap ticket, gorgeous French-era building.

EVE — Round two of pho at a fresh spot — broth showdown.

Food: Pho Le / Pho 2000 — ~60,000 VND.

■ *Traffic tip: Hop a Grab motorbike between stops — weaves through jams instead of idling in them.*

DAY 5 · Wed

Cholon's Lantern Streets

AM — Motorbike into Cholon before 9am; smoke-coiled Thien Hau Pagoda.

PM — Get lost in Binh Tay Market's maze of stalls and snacks.

EVE — Street-food crawl back toward D1, one skewer at a time.

Food: Cholon street banh mi — ~25,000 VND.

■ *Traffic tip: Head back before 4:30pm, when the route to D1 turns into a parking lot.*

DAY 6 · Thu

Down the Mekong

AM — Budget boat tour (My Tho or Ben Tre) — palm-lined canals, slower pace.

PM — Drift past floating markets and orchards; fruit & tea tasting on board.

EVE — Back in Saigon by early evening for a low-key noodle dinner.

Food: Fresh coconut & tropical fruit — usually included in the tour.

■ *Traffic tip: Book a pre-8am departure — later ones crawl out of the city.*

DAY 7 · Fri

One Last Bowl

AM — Free morning — chase down your favourite pho or banh mi one more time.

PM — Haggle for souvenirs at Ben Thanh Market.

EVE — Head to the airport with time to spare — no rushed goodbyes.

Food: Farewell pho + banh mi combo — ~100,000 VND, the two loves of the trip.

■ *Traffic tip: Leave 3+ hours early — it's a short distance but a slow crawl to Tan Son Nhat.*

BUDGET & STYLE

Hostel dorms in D1 (Bui Vien/Pham Ngu Lao), street eats (15,000–70,000 VND/dish), Grab bike for the long hauls, your own two feet for the rest.

GOLDEN RULE FOR THIS TRIP

The city seizes up 7–9am and 4:30–7pm. Book day-trips & airport runs **outside** those windows, keep D1 on foot, and let a Grab motorbike slice through the jam.

Getting around: feet for D1 · Grab bike to weave through traffic · Grab car for late nights or heavy bags · always confirm the fare first.

Marcus's Saigon Week · Uni Break Trip · Cultural food, museums & historic sites, budget-backpacker style